

CHELYS SECURITY

Customer Discovery Package

Interview guides, outreach templates, and objection handling for sales conversations with CISOs, security engineers, and IT leaders. Built for Chelys Security — autonomous AI pentest platform.

WHAT'S INSIDE

- Part 1 — Target Personas
- Part 2 — Interview Guide (25-min discovery call)
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1

Target Personas

Know who you're talking to before you open your mouth.

Persona	Title	What They Care About	Budget Authority
Exec Buyer	CISO, VP Security	Risk reduction, board optics, not getting blamed for a breach	Full authority
Technical Evaluator	Security Engineer Pentest Lead, Red Teamer	Tool depth, low false-positive rate, workflow integration	Influence only
Stretched IT Leader	IT Director / Head of IT (SMB)	Coverage without added headcount, compliance checkbox	Full authority
Consultant / MSP	Freelance PT, Managed Security Provider	Speed, client deliverable quality, margin	Full for own stack

Prioritize Exec Buyer and Technical Evaluator for first 6 months. Consultant/MSP channel unlocks 10× deal velocity but needs white-label reporting first.

2

Interview Guide

25-minute discovery call. You listen 80%. No demo until you've heard the full picture.

CALL PRINCIPLES

- Listen 80%, talk 20% — silence is data, don't fill it
- Every one-word answer needs a follow-up: "Tell me more about that" / "Why?" / "What did that cost you?"
- Goal: current workflow → pain → cost of pain → ideal outcome → budget/process
- Do NOT pitch. If they ask what you do, deflect until you have their full picture.
- Take notes verbatim — their words become your pitch language later.

Opening (2 min)

"Thanks for the time. My only goal today is to understand how your team handles offensive security right now — not to pitch anything. If what we're building doesn't actually solve a problem you have, I want to know that. Fair?"

This disarms skepticism and signals confidence. Say it and wait for the "sure" before moving on.

Section A — Current State (8 min)

Q1 Walk me through the last time you had a pentest done — from the moment you decided you needed one to when you saw the results.

- *How long did that take start to finish?*
- *Who ran it — internal team, external firm, or both?*

Q2 What happens to the report after the pentest closes?

- *Who owns remediation? How do you track it?*
- *How long does it typically take to close a critical finding?*

Q3 How much of your network or application surface actually got tested in the last engagement?

Why ask this: Most will admit it's a fraction. This surfaces the continuous coverage gap without you having to name it.

Q4 What do you do between pentests — quarterly, monthly — to know if you're exposed?

Why ask this: Dead silence is common here. That silence IS the answer.

Section B — Pain and Cost (8 min)

Q5 What's the part of your current pentest process that's most broken or frustrating?

- *Let them finish. Don't fill silences.*
- *"Anything else?" — asked once, after they stop.*

Q6 Has there ever been a finding that your pentest missed that you found another way?

- *What happened?*
- *What did that cost — in dollars, hours, or awkward board conversations?*

Q7 When a critical CVE drops and you need to know your exposure in 48 hours — what does that actually look like right now?

Why ask this: Everyone has a war story here. You want the story, not the policy.

★ MAGIC QUESTION

"If I could snap my fingers and fix one thing about how you handle offensive security, what would it be?"

Don't rush this answer. The first thing they say is rarely the real thing — wait for the pause, then ask: "Is that the biggest one, or is there something else underneath it?"

Q9 What's the dollar or time cost you'd attach to that problem?

Why ask this: They may not know — that's fine. An unquantified pain is still a pain worth noting.

Section C — Buying Criteria and Alternatives (5 min)

Q10 What tools are you using for automated vulnerability scanning right now — Tenable, Qualys, Rapid7?

■ How's that working? What does it miss?

Q11 Have you looked at Pentera, NodeZero, or Horizon3.ai?

- What happened — did you trial it, buy it, or reject it?
- Why did you go that direction / why didn't you buy?

Why ask this: This surfaces your real competitors and the exact objections you'll face later in the call.

Q12 What would something have to do — or prove — for you to replace or augment your current process?

Why ask this: Write their answer verbatim. This is their buying criteria in their own words. Use it back at them in the demo.

Section D — Close (2 min)

Q13 Is this a problem you're actively trying to solve right now, or more on the radar for later?

Why ask this: "Active" = qualified. "Radar" = nurture. Don't confuse the two.

Q14 Who else would be involved in evaluating something like this if you decided to move forward?

Why ask this: Maps the buying committee. If they say "just me," verify — most security purchases have at least 2 approvers.

IF pain was real: "Based on what you've told me — does it make sense to show you what we're building and get your honest reaction?"

IF pain was weak: "I don't think we're the right fit for you right now — but can I stay in touch for when [X they mentioned] becomes a priority?"

Expert Interview Guide

Use when talking to: independent security researchers, pentest firm founders, security VCs, CISO advisors. Goal is to validate technical assumptions and market positioning — not sell.

- 1 If you were building the automated pentest platform that would actually win in this market, what would it have to do that nothing does today?
- 2 Where do you see Pentera and NodeZero falling short with their current customers?

3	What's the failure mode you've seen most often with AI-assisted security tools in production?
4	If I told you a platform could do autonomous multi-hop lateral movement safely — what's your reaction? Where does the skepticism come from?
5	Who are the ideal first 10 customers for something like this? What company, what role, what exact pain?
6	What would make you comfortable recommending this to a client or portfolio company?

3

Outreach Templates

5 templates for 5 contexts. Under 100 words for cold. Specific over generic, always.

**3A • Cold Email —
CISO / VP
Security**

Subject: How [Company] handles pentest gaps between engagements

Hi [Name],

Most security teams I talk to run a pentest once a year, get a 60-page PDF, and spend the next 11 months not knowing whether the network they have now matches the network that was tested.

We're building an autonomous platform that runs continuous attack simulation — same techniques a red teamer uses, but on-demand and with a full audit trail. Currently working with a few security leads to make sure we've built the right thing.

Worth 20 minutes to give me your honest reaction?

— Alejandro

Why this works: First sentence names a real pain without pitching. The ask is 'honest reaction' — not a demo, not a sales call. Low friction.

**3B • Cold Email —
Security Engineer
/ Pentest Lead**

Subject: Autonomous pentest platform — looking for technical feedback

Hi [Name],

Building an AI-native pentest platform — think automated red team that chains recon → exploitation → lateral movement, not just a scanner with a prettier dashboard.

We're at the stage where honest technical feedback from people who actually do this work matters more than sales calls. If you have 20 minutes to poke holes in our approach, I'd genuinely appreciate it — and I'll show you the full stack.

Interested?

— Alejandro

Why this works: Engineers hate being sold to. Framing as 'feedback' and 'poke holes' signals confidence and earns respect. They will have opinions.

3C • LinkedIn DM — Warm-ish / Conference Connection

Hey [Name] — noticed you're [at a company that recently had a breach / gave a talk on red teaming / in a CISO role in fintech or healthcare].

Building an autonomous pentest platform and looking for practitioners who'd give me an unfiltered take on whether we're solving the right problem. 20 minutes — no deck, no pitch. Just conversation.

Worth it?

Why this works: Keep it short. LinkedIn DMs that pitch get ignored. Questions get responses. Reference something specific about them.

3D • Warm Intro Request — To a Mutual Connection

Hey [Connector],

I'm doing customer discovery for Chelys Security — building an autonomous AI pentest platform and trying to get 20-minute conversations with CISOs and security leads before we go to market.

You mentioned you know [Prospect]. Would you be comfortable doing a quick intro? Happy to draft the note if helpful.

Either way, thanks.

Why this works: 'Would you be comfortable' is easier to say yes to than 'can you.' Offer to write the note — reduce their effort to zero.

3E • Post-Conference Follow-Up

Hey [Name] — good to meet at [event]. You mentioned [specific thing they said].

Building something directly related to that problem. Would love 20 minutes to show you where we are and get your honest reaction — not a pitch, just want to know if we're solving the right thing.

This week or next work?

Why this works: Reference something specific they said — 'great to meet you' follow-ups get deleted. The more specific the callback, the higher the reply rate.

4

Customer Reaction Simulator

10 common objections — what they say, what they mean, and exactly what to say back.

1

"We already use Pentera / NodeZero."

WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN

Convince me why switching is worth the pain. (If they hated it, they'd have led with that.)

RESPONSE

"Good to know — you've already made the mental leap that this category of tooling is worth paying for. That's helpful context."

"What's made you keep it rather than go a different direction? I'm curious what's working and what isn't."

→ Pull out their frustrations. Then: "That's exactly what we're built differently to address."

SIGNAL?

Buying Signal — Happy Pentera customers still have gaps. Unhappy ones convert easily. Either way this opens a real conversation.

2

"We do our own pentesting in-house."

WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN

'I don't want to look like I don't trust my team' — or they genuinely think they have coverage.

RESPONSE

"That's great — your team knows your environment better than any external firm would."

"What we hear from teams like yours is that the bottleneck isn't skill, it's bandwidth — the team has more surface to cover than hours to cover it. Does that map to your situation?"

If yes → "We're not replacing your team, we're giving them 10× the coverage."

If no → "What does your team's current capacity look like for proactive vs. reactive work?"

SIGNAL?

Buying Signal — Buying signal if they have a security team but limited time. Red flag only if they have a 20-person red team with no real gaps.

3

*"AI hacking tools make me nervous — what if it does something it's not supposed to?"***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

I'm worried about liability and losing control. This is legitimate — treat it seriously.

RESPONSE

"That's the right question to ask and I'll give you a straight answer."

"Everything runs in scope-limited mode — the Safety Oracle blocks lateral movement past defined boundaries, stops before any destructive action, and requires explicit confirmation for anything that would touch production. Full audit trail of every action. You can kill it in under 30 seconds."

"What would you need to see to feel confident about the blast radius controls before you'd run it in your environment?"

SIGNAL?

Buying Signal — Strong buying signal. Skepticism about safety means they're taking it seriously, not dismissing it. The cautious ones become your best advocates once they verify the controls.

4

*"We can't have a third-party tool running on our network."***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

Could be policy. Could be a proxy for 'we haven't approved this vendor yet.' Needs diagnosis.

RESPONSE

"Totally understand. Is that a policy that's absolute, or is it more about the vendor vetting process?"

"A lot of our conversations start there — we've worked with security teams through SOC2 review, data handling, network isolation, and the full evaluation checklist. If it's the vetting process, we can support that. If it's a hard policy against any third-party tooling, I want to understand that."

SIGNAL?

Soft Red Flag — Still a deal if they can describe the vetting path. Hard 'no external tools ever' (government, ultra-regulated) — walk away gracefully.

5

*"How is this different from just running Nessus?"***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

'I'm not sure this is worth more than what I have.' They may not understand the category yet.

RESPONSE

"Great comparison point. Nessus tells you what vulnerabilities exist. We tell you what can actually be exploited, chained, and used to reach your crown jewels — because we do the same thing an attacker does."

"A scanner finds the unlocked door. We walk in, move through the building, and show you exactly where your sensitive data is reachable. The output isn't a CVE list — it's an attack path with video evidence and a risk score based on actual exploitability, not theoretical CVSS."

SIGNAL?

Buying Signal — Buying signal. They're educating themselves. Help them see the difference between 'vulnerability exists' and 'vulnerability is exploitable and chains to impact.'

6

*"What if it finds something real and takes down production?"***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

'I need someone to blame if this goes wrong.' Legitimate concern, not a dealbreaker.

RESPONSE

"That's exactly why we built the Safety Oracle before we built anything else. It runs before every action — if a technique would cause service disruption, data modification, or leave a persistent artifact, it's blocked, logged, and flagged."

"The platform is built to prove exposure without causing it. We can also start in a staging or isolated network segment so you can verify the safety controls before touching prod."

"What would you need to see to feel confident?"

SIGNAL?

Buying Signal — Procurement conversation, not a dismissal. They're mentally modeling how they'd deploy it — that's a buying behavior.

7

*"We don't have budget right now."***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

Could mean 4 different things: fiscal timing, low priority, needs different pricing, or testing you.

RESPONSE

"Understood. Is this a 'not this quarter' or more of a 'this isn't on the roadmap'?"

"I ask because our pricing is designed around cost-per-scan rather than a large annual commit — the math for a lot of teams works out to less than one hour of external pentest firm time per month."

"But if timing is genuinely the constraint, I'd rather stay in touch for when it makes sense than push a deal that isn't ready."

→ Ask: "When does your budget cycle open?"

SIGNAL?

Soft Red Flag — If they engage with 'when does budget open' — it's timing, worth chasing. If they deflect that question too — it's a priority problem, not a budget problem.

8

*"Send me a whitepaper / datasheet and we'll circle back."***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

I want to exit this conversation politely.

RESPONSE

"Happy to — though I'll be honest, most people who say that don't end up reading it, and I don't want to waste your time."

"Is there something specific you'd want to see in a document that you couldn't get from a 20-minute live walkthrough? The demo usually answers more questions faster."

If they still want the doc → send it. Then: "I'll send it over. Is [specific date] a reasonable time to check back on whether it answered your questions?"

SIGNAL?

Soft Red Flag — Soft red flag unless you can convert it to a specific follow-up commitment. A date on the calendar is worth 10 promises to 'circle back.'

9

*"I need to run this by my CISO / board / team."***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

Almost always legitimate — security purchases rarely happen with one approver.

RESPONSE

"Of course. Can I help make that easier?"

"Would it be useful to have a 20-minute call with them directly, or would a one-page technical brief covering safety controls, data handling, and competitive differentiation be more useful for that conversation?"

"I want to make sure they're getting accurate information rather than a game of telephone."

→ Goal: get into the next meeting yourself. Don't leave it entirely to your champion.

SIGNAL?**Buying Signal** — Buying signal. Champions over-simplify your value prop to internal stakeholders. Your job is to get into that room.1
0*"What's the price?"***WHAT THEY
ACTUALLY MEAN**

Sometimes genuine. Sometimes a test to see if you flinch. Context determines which.

RESPONSE

Early in call: "I'll give you a straight answer in a minute — I want to make sure I give you the right number because it depends on scan volume and team size. Can I ask a few quick questions first?"

Late in call, after pain is established: "Starter tier is [price]/month — includes [X] scans, teams up to [Y]."

"To put it in context: one external pentest engagement from a firm runs \$15–50K and takes 2–4 weeks. We're faster, on-demand, and under your control."

→ Never apologize for price. Anchor it against what they're already spending.

SIGNAL?**Buying Signal** — Asking about price is a buying behavior. Anchor against external firm cost (\$15–50K/engagement) or breach cost, never against competing SaaS tools.

5

Qualification Scorecard

Score every call within 10 minutes of hanging up. Stack-rank your pipeline weekly.

Score	Signal
+3	Described a specific recent pain in their own words
+2	Has done a pentest in the last 12 months
+2	Has a dedicated security team (even 1 person)
+2	Named a competitor they evaluated or use
+2	Has an active compliance requirement (SOC2, PCI, HIPAA, HITRUST)
+2	Asked a technical question about how it works
+2	Has a budget cycle opening in 90 days
+1	Volunteered who else is involved in decisions
+1	Asked about pricing
+1	Asked about safety controls or blast radius
-1	Couldn't name their current pentest vendor
-2	Said 'send me a datasheet' with no follow-up date agreed
-2	Under 50 employees, no dedicated security person
-3	Said 'we don't really do pentesting'

SCORE 8+	Active Opportunity	Move to demo this week. Identify buying committee. Propose a specific date.
SCORE 4-7	Nurture	Monthly touchpoint. Share relevant content (CVE drops, incident news relevant to their stack). Re-qualify quarterly.
SCORE < 4	Not Qualified	Exit gracefully. 'I don't think we're the right fit yet — is it okay if I reach back out in 6 months?' Saves your time.

Run this score within 10 minutes of every call, while the conversation is fresh. Review your pipeline score distribution weekly — if your average score is below 5, you're spending time with the wrong ICP.